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4 | Common ground

If a lion could talk, we could not understand him.
Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*

Everything we do is rooted in information we have about our surroundings, activities, perceptions, emotions, plans, interests. Everything we do jointly with others is also rooted in this information, but only in that part we think they share with us. The notion needed here is common ground.

Common ground is a *sine qua non* for everything we do with others – from the broadest joint activities (Chapter 2) to the smallest joint actions that comprise them (Chapter 3). For my son and me to act jointly, he and I have to coordinate what we do and when we do it. And to coordinate, we have to appeal, ultimately, to our current common ground. At the same time, with every joint action he and I perform, we add to our common ground. This is how joint activities, from chess games to business transactions, progress (Chapter 2). When my son and I enter a conversation, we presuppose certain common ground, and with each joint action – each utterance, for example – we try to add to it. To do that, we need to keep track of our common ground as it accumulates increment by increment.

Common ground is important to any account of language use that appeals to "context." Most accounts don't say what context is, but rely on our intuitions about the circumstances of each utterance. These appeals are no better than a psychic's visions of next year's stock prices – and less predictive. With an undefined notion of context, as with an indefinite future, anything is possible. What these approaches need is a proper theory of common ground.

What, then, is common ground? What forms does it take? What information does it represent? How is it created, maintained, and incremented?

HUMAN NATURE

Whenever I meet other humans – adults from anywhere in the world – I assume as common ground that they and I think in the same way about many things. I may be wrong, but I would still draw the inferences, and these would inform my actions as we tried to coordinate with each other. I possess a folk psychology about people in general – about human nature – and, right or wrong, it allows me to get started.

All of us take as common ground, I assume, that people normally have the same senses, sense organs, and types of sensations. If a sound is audible to me, it would normally be audible to others in the same circumstances. People also perceive motion, perceptual depth, pitches, and rhythms, and assume these ways of perceiving to be common ground. Less obviously, people are limited in what they can attend to at once, and the raw perceptual experiences that grab my attention – loud noises or sudden movements – will grab yours too. Certain varieties of perceptual salience are common ground to us all.

We all take it as common ground, also, that everyone knows the basic facts and laws of nature. People universally assume that they live in a world populated by animate and inanimate objects that are subject to gravity, Newton-like laws of motion, and laws of cause and effect. They take certain facts of biology for granted – for example, that animate things are born, take in food and water to live, then cease to function. They suppose that everyone assumes certain social facts – that people generally possess and use language, live together in groups, exchange goods and services, have names, play roles in various institutions, and so on. It is hard to exaggerate the number and variety of basic concepts we take as common ground to everyone.

COMMUNAL LEXICONS

Many inferences are based more narrowly on the language communities we know someone belongs to. If Soonja is a Korean speaker, I assume she takes as common ground to Korean speakers all the conventional features of Korean – its phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, and pragmatics. This follows from Lewis' characterization of conventions as common knowledge within a community of speakers (Chapter 3). Precisely how these conventions are represented is a fundamental question for students of language, and there are diverse proposals on the table. I also assume Soonja takes for granted certain facts about how Korean speakers speak and understand – that they need more time and effort to deal with some aspects of Korean than others. All this is outside information that I take as common ground about using any language.

In Lewis' account, conventional word meanings hold not for a word *simpliciter*, but for a word *in a particular community*. You can't talk about conventional word meaning without saying what community it is conventional in. Word knowledge, properly viewed, divides into what I will call communal lexicons, by which I mean sets of word conventions in individual communities. When I meet Ann, she and I must establish as common ground which communities we both belong to simply in order to know what English words we can use with what meaning. Can I use *fermata*? Not without establishing that we are both music enthusiasts. Can I use *rbi*? Not without establishing that we are both baseball fans.

Every community has a specialized lexicon. We recognize these lexicons in the terms we have for them in English:

Residence	regional or local dialects, patois, provincialisms, localisms, regionalisms, colloquialisms, idiom, Americanisms, etc.
Occupation	jargon, shoptalk, parlance, nomenclature, technical terminology, academese, legalese, medicalese, Wall Streetese, etc.
Subculture	slang, argot, lingo, cant, vernacular, code, etc.

Most regions have their own dialect, patois, idiom, or regionalisms, with distinctive terms for everything from food to geographical features. Most occupations and hobbies, from physics to philately, have a technical jargon or terminology. So do most subcultures, from drug addicts to high school cliques.

When we think of jargon, slang, and regionalisms, we tend to focus on the words unique to a communal lexicon. *Meson*, *pion*, and *quark* are terms only a physicist could love. But most common word forms belong to many communal lexicons – though with different conventional meanings. In Britain, *biscuits* can be sweet or savory, but in America, they are always savory. In common parlance, *fruit* denotes a class of edible, sweet, fleshy agricultural products; among botanists, it denotes the ripened ovary or ovaries of seed-bearing plants, whether or not they are edible, sweet, and fleshy. Two botanists in conversation would have to establish which lexicon they were drawing on. You and I would be forced to stay with common parlance. It is essential to identify the cultural communities our interlocutors do and don't belong to just to know what vocabulary we can use.